# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

**Donald Trump** said he did not want a ceasefire with **Iran**. “You don’t do a ceasefire when you are literally obliterating the other side,” he added. Mr Trump said NATO allies lacked “courage” to help America reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Earlier **Britain** gave America access to its bases to launch strikes on Iranian sites that were being used to attack ships in the strait. America is reportedly sending at least 2,200 more **marines** to the Middle East.

The price of **Brent crude**, the global oil benchmark, reached $112 a barrel as fears of a global energy shortage grew. Reports that Iraq declared *force majeure* on shipments from its foreign-operated oilfields, implying that it cannot fulfil its contractual obligations, contributed to the rise. As did mounting speculation of an American operation on **Kharg Island**, the site of Iran’s main oil terminal.

Meanwhile **American stocks** fell; the S&P 500 and the NASDAQ closed 1.5% and 2% lower respectively. The **International Energy Agency**, an intergovernmental organisation, recommended that people work from home as an emergency response to the “largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market”. It also suggested car sharing and avoiding air travel.

NATO said it withdrew all personnel from its mission in **Iraq** and moved them to Italy. Its base was located near America's embassy in Baghdad, which has repeatedly been targeted by Iranian strikes. The non-combat mission, which was created in 2018, assists Iraq with counter-terrorism efforts that include preventing the return of Islamic State.

**Colombia's** president, **Gustavo Petro**, is being investigated by American criminal prosecutors over alleged connections to drug traffickers, according to media reports. The drug probe apparently spans wider than Mr Petro; an unnamed source told Reuters that it was not "squarely focused on him". Mr Trump has previously called Mr Petro an "illegal drug trafficker", an accusation he denies.

**ByteDance**, the Chinese owner of TikTok, reached an agreement to sell Moonton, a gaming studio, to Savvy Games Group, a subsidiary of Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund, for around $6bn. ByteDance paid $4bn for the business in 2021. The sale marks the company's exit from the **gaming market**, where it failed to compete with larger Chinese rivals such as Tencent.

**Chuck Norris** died at the age of 86. The martial-arts star had his cinema debut alongside Bruce Lee in "The Way of the Dragon" in 1972; he later acted in the TV series "Walker, Texas Ranger". His popularity took off again in the 2000s with Chuck Norris facts, deadpan memes about his exaggerated toughness. Tributes came from fellow actors Sylvester Stallone and Jean-Claude Van Damme.

**Figure of the day: 7.2%**, the amount by which Cuba's GDP is forecast to shrink in 2026. Read the full story.

Photograph: Reuters

# Iranians' unhappy new year

In Iran, this weekend should have been festive. Unusually, the spring festival of Nowruz coincides with Eid, which marks the end of Ramadan. Iranians would normally flock to seaside resorts or picnic in the mountains. Instead, many are sheltering in stairwells, worn down by three weeks of bombardment. America claims to have struck 7,000 targets; Israel thousands more. More than 3,000 Iranians have been killed, including at least 1,300 civilians, according to HRANA, a human-rights group.

But America and Israel have not succeeded in triggering their promised popular uprising. America appears to have stepped back from its initial pursuit of regime change. However, Israel and Reza Pahlavi, the former Shah's son, continue to urge Iranians to take to the streets, most recently for this week's fire festival, ahead of Nowruz. So far their calls have not been answered. Instead Israel created fireworks by bombing the South Pars gas field, which supplies much of Iran's fuel.

Photograph: Reuters

## A spying scandal hangs over Slovenia's election

As Friday ends Slovenia will plunge into electoral silence ahead of its vote on Sunday. The final week of campaigning has been anything but quiet. Local media alleged that Janez Jansa (pictured), the populist opposition leader, met with operatives from Black Cube, an Israeli political-intelligence firm. Their report suggests Black Cube published footage earlier this month that appeared to implicate several people connected to the government in corruption. Those captured in the videos deny wrongdoing; Black Cube did not respond to our request for comment.

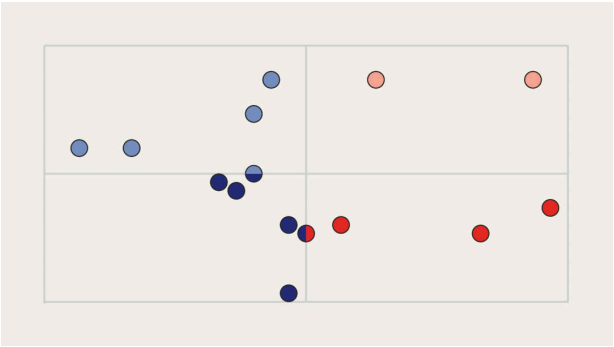
Mr Jansa, a three-time prime minister and an ally of Viktor Orban, Hungary's strongman, denies being part of a plot, but says the footage shows the government is crooked. His party praised Black Cube for purportedly exposing graft. Robert Golob, the liberal prime minister, has warned of foreign interference. Slovenia's election may now hinge on whether voters are more concerned by what the videos revealed, or by who made them.

Photograph: AP

## Excitement and anxiety at BTS's return

The world's biggest boyband is back. BTS released their long-anticipated new album on Friday. In 2019 the K-pop act became the first band since the Beatles to have three chart-topping albums in under a year. But in 2022 the group—whose full name translates as "Bulletproof Boy Scouts"—took a break to complete their mandatory military service. Some 260,000 fans, many from abroad, are expected to attend their free comeback concert in Seoul on Saturday. It will also be live-streamed on Netflix.

Such a popular event will benefit the local economy. Yet Koreans are jittery about the arrival of the ARMY (as the group's global fans are known). The city is still haunted by the deadly crowd crush which killed more than 150 Halloween revellers in 2022. Officials are closing roads, rerouting public transport, shutting nearby attractions and dispatching thousands of police around Saturday's show. The capital is determined to have only happy memories of BTS's return.



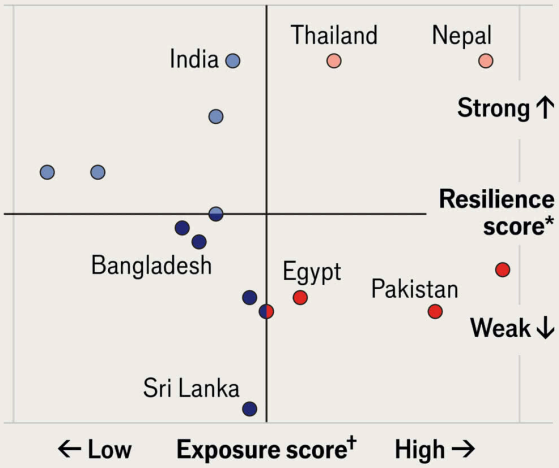
Photograph:

## Data bite: Who will expensive energy hurt most?

Some emerging economies are more vulnerable to global energy shocks than others. To judge which are likely to suffer most from the current crisis, we measured countries' reliance on imported energy and on aid and remittances from the Gulf. We also sized up their foreign-exchange reserves. Pakistan and Egypt are in trouble: both import a lot of oil and gas; their stock of foreign exchange is low. Better off are two other big energy importers: Nepal, which has plenty of hard currency, and Thailand, which has large oil reserves. Bangladesh and Sri Lanka rely less on energy imports, but their foreign-currency cushions are thin. Read our analysis.

## The insulated and the isolated

**Emerging markets, exposure and resilience to Iran war oil shock, 2024 or latest**




*Based on foreign-exchange reserves & external government debt †Based on net oil & gas imports, oil & gas imports from the Middle East & Gulf remittances
Sources: UN; World Bank; IMF; national statistics; *The Economist*

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

# Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [email protected]. We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

**Friday:** Which 1950 novel by Ray Bradbury is set on another planet?

**Thursday:** What word is used for a demand that must be met within a set period of time?

*The spirit of truth and the spirit of freedom—these are the pillars of society.*

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***Henrik Ibsen***